

Blue-winged kookaburra

Dacelo leachii

Kookaburras, famous for their rising and falling “jackass” braying calls, are “tree kingfishers” of Australia and New Guinea. They perch conspicuously in trees, looking around from side to side, and drop to the ground to catch their prey. They concentrate especially on big insects, small reptiles, and frogs, although anything from worms to small birds and rodents are dealt with by the wide, heavy beak. The blue-winged kookaburra is slightly smaller than the more familiar laughing kookaburra, and has a particularly prolonged, manic laughing and cackling call.

Helpful big brother

Kookaburras pair for life and are assisted in defending their nest and raising their young by one or two male “helpers” from earlier broods, an uncommon system in birds. The female incubates her eggs in a hollow in a high tree branch, where they are vulnerable to snakes. Usually two or three chicks survive and fly after 36 days, but it takes 10 weeks before they are fully independent.



↔ 15–17 in (38–43 cm)

⚖ 11oz (310 g)

⊗ Common

🐛 Insects, reptiles, frogs, fish

🏠

S. Papua New Guinea, NW. to NE. Australia

◀ **BEGGING FOR FOOD**
Chicks compete with each other for food, and two or three older chicks may kill the weakest, youngest one while they are still in the nest.

Plumed whistling-duck

Dendrocygna eytoni

Although whistling-ducks often graze on dry land, they require easy access to water. They feed mainly at night and may fly up to 20 miles (30km) to reach favored feeding places. Their nests are lined with soft grass, not with down plucked from the female’s own body.

↔ 16–24 in (41–61 cm)

⚖ 1–4lb (0.5–1.8 kg)

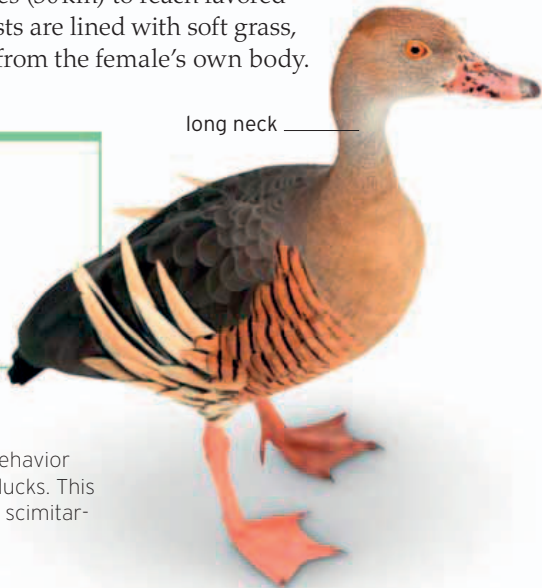
⊗ Common

🌾 Grass

🏠

📍 N. and E. Australia

long neck



▷ **LOOKING SHARP**
Petite heads and sociable behavior characterize the whistling-ducks. This species has distinctive pale, scimitar-like flank feathers.

Purple-crowned fairy wren

Malurus coronatus

One of 14 species of fairy wrens that forage in dense low growth, the purple-crowned fairy wren is found in long grass close to a river. Males have brilliant blue patterns. A male and female form a pair to raise the young, but each mates with other birds and helps raise the chicks from those pairings too, creating a complex social structure.

↔ 6 in (15 cm)

⚖ $\frac{5}{16}$ – $\frac{7}{16}$ oz (9–13 g)

⊗ Common

🐛 Insects

🏠

📍 N. Australia



◀ **UPRIGHT TAIL**
The cocked tail seemed familiar when Europeans first reached Australia, but fairy wrens are not related to Northern Hemisphere wrens.